

Preventive Care

Separate after-care instructions for Fluoride Application & Pit and Fissure Sealants

Preventive dental care helps protect teeth before problems develop. Your dentist's personalised instructions always take priority.

Fluoride Application

After-care following professional fluoride treatment

WHAT IS NORMAL?

A temporary coating or slightly different feeling on the teeth can occur after some fluoride treatments. Follow the specific instructions given by your dentist because recommendations vary with the fluoride product used.

REMEMBER

Fluoride works best when it stays in contact with the teeth. Follow the recommended waiting period before eating, drinking or brushing.

1. Immediately after treatment

- Follow your dentist's instructions about how long to avoid eating or drinking.
- If a fluoride varnish has been applied, avoid brushing or flossing the treated areas for the period advised by your dentist.
- Do not deliberately scrape or remove the fluoride coating.

2. Eating and drinking

- For fluoride varnish, choose soft foods if advised and avoid very hot or hard foods during the recommended period.
- Follow any product-specific instructions regarding milk, dairy products or other foods.
- Once the advised waiting period is over, return to your usual diet unless your dentist says otherwise.

3. Oral hygiene

- Resume normal brushing and interdental cleaning according to the instructions given for the particular fluoride treatment.
- Continue brushing twice daily with fluoride toothpaste.
- Do not use more fluoride products than recommended.

4. Why it helps

- Fluoride strengthens tooth enamel and helps teeth resist acid attacks.
- Regular fluoride exposure can help reduce the risk of tooth decay.
- Fluoride treatment works best together with good brushing, diet and regular dental care.

5. Contact your dentist if

- You develop unusual or persistent irritation.
- You have an unexpected reaction after treatment.
- You are unsure when to eat, drink, brush or floss after the application.

Pit & Fissure Sealants

After-care following placement of preventive dental sealants

WHAT IS NORMAL?

The sealed tooth may feel slightly different when you bite for a short time. The material is placed in the grooves of the tooth to make them easier to keep clean.

REMEMBER

Sealants protect vulnerable grooves but do not replace brushing, fluoride or regular dental check-ups.

1. Eating after sealant placement

- If local anaesthetic was used, wait until numbness has completely worn off before eating.
- If no anaesthetic was used, normal eating is usually possible unless your dentist gives different instructions.
- Avoid very hard or sticky foods if the tooth feels unusual or tender.

2. Getting used to the sealant

- The sealed tooth may initially feel slightly different to your tongue.
- Your bite should normally feel comfortable.
- If your bite feels high or uncomfortable, contact your dentist rather than trying to alter the sealant yourself.

3. Daily oral hygiene

- Brush twice daily with fluoride toothpaste.
- Clean between the teeth every day.
- Brush over the sealed tooth normally and keep the surrounding gums healthy.

4. Protecting the sealant

- Do not bite ice, pens, nails or other hard objects.
- Sticky foods can place extra stress on restorations and should be limited.
- Sealants can wear or chip over time and should be checked during routine dental visits.

5. Why it helps

- Sealants cover deep grooves and pits where food and plaque can collect.
- They make these areas easier to clean and help reduce the risk of decay.
- Sealants are especially useful for teeth with deep or difficult-to-clean grooves.

6. Contact your dentist if

- The sealant feels loose, rough or has come away.
- The tooth becomes painful or persistently sensitive.
- Your bite feels high or uncomfortable.
- You notice food repeatedly catching around the treated tooth.

Preventive Care: Everyday Protection

Simple habits make preventive treatment work better

Preventive treatments are most effective when combined with everyday oral care.

Brush twice daily

- Use fluoride toothpaste and brush all tooth surfaces gently.
- Spit after brushing rather than immediately rinsing away all the fluoride.

Clean between your teeth

- Use floss or an interdental cleaning method recommended by your dentist.
- Pay attention to areas where food commonly gets trapped.

Watch your diet

- Limit frequent sugary snacks and drinks.
- Water is a good choice between meals.

Keep regular dental visits

- Fluoride applications and sealants should be reviewed as part of routine dental care.
- Your dentist can check whether a sealant remains intact and whether additional preventive treatment is needed.

References

1. American Dental Association. Fluoride: topical fluoride and caries prevention—patient and professional education resources.
2. American Dental Association. Dental sealants: patient information and caries prevention resources.
3. American Academy of Pediatric Dentistry. Fluoride Therapy and Pit and Fissure Sealants: clinical guidance.
4. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention. Community Water Fluoridation and dental caries prevention resources.